That night, having ascended to the top of the pass, the British found themselves in an even colder camp site than the night before. Snow began to fall towards evening, developing into a full-scale blizzard by nine at night. For the entire army, only four tents remained, one of which was assigned to Lady Sale and her daughter. There was no fuel or food, but at least some of the doctors still had their medicine bags. Dr Brydon's friend and Scottish compatriot Dr Alexander Bryce 'came and examined Sturt's wound', wrote Lady Sale. 'He dressed it; but I saw by the countenance in his expression that there was no hope. He afterwards kindly cut the ball out of my wrist; and dressed both my wounds . . . [That night] the sipahees and camp followers, half frozen, tried to force their way not only into our tent but into our beds . . . Many poor wretches died round the tent in the night . . . Many women and children abducted.'[44]

'The snow was the only bed for all,' wrote Eyre, 'and for many, ere morning, it proved the winding sheet. It was only marvellous that any of us at all should have survived that fearful night!' Maulana Hamid Kashmiri echoed the thought in his *Akbarnama*:

> The winter, with its very heartlessness
> Showered love upon the brave people of Kabul
> For if the Kafirs did not die of the snow
> Or by the swords of the plundering looters
>
> To hyenas, wolves and jackals, from every side
> The fox called out, bidding them to a feast of meat
>
> Kites circled above and cried out far
> A generous invitation to all beasts of prey
>
> Upon that road how many escaped alive?
> All were thrown down, and laid low in the snow[45]

On the fourth morning of the retreat, 9 January, in the middle of a high-altitude sub-zero blizzard, desperation finally gave way to complete despair. 'The flesh from men's feet was peeling off in flakes,' recorded Captain William Anderson, one of the last survivors of Shah Shuja's Contingent. 'Scores had been frozen to death in the night.'[46]

As the blizzard continued to rage with greater intensity than ever, only one mile of progress was made in the entire day. 'The sky on all sides filled with snow,' recorded Munshi Abdul Karim,